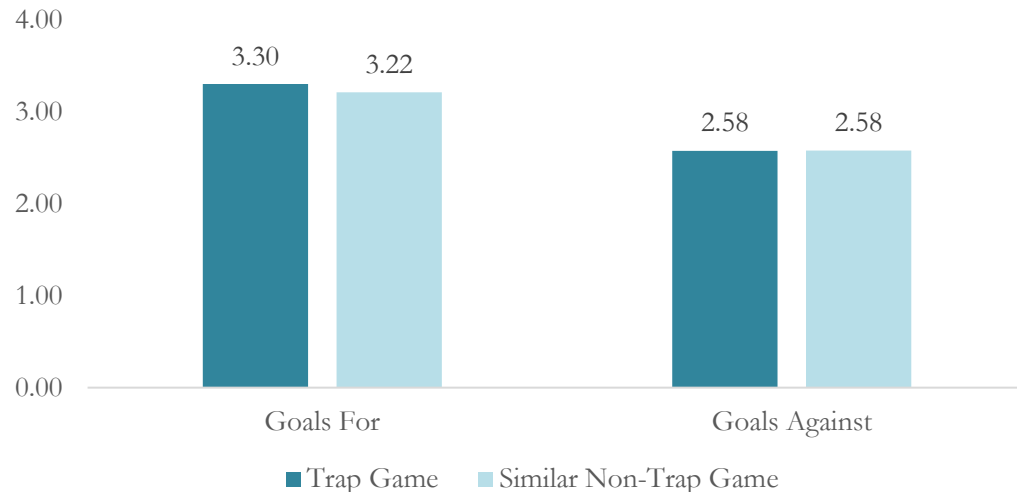


The Myth of NHL Trap Games: A Systematic Analysis

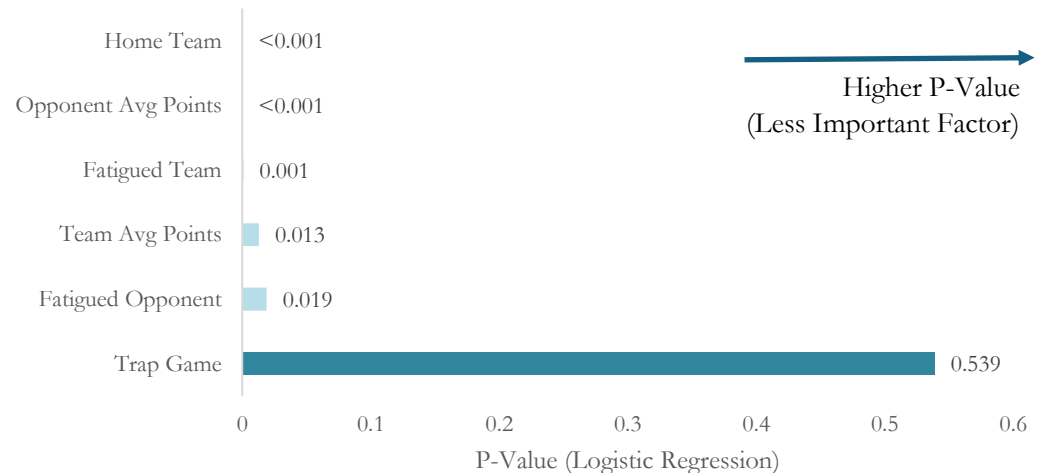
Trap Games are a popular narrative with limited systematic evidence across nearly two decades of NHL seasons.

- Teams perform better on average in trap games than they do in similar non-trap games.
- Some teams underperform in trap games, however statistical evidence is weak.
- Strong teams playing back-to-back do better in trap games than they would otherwise playing back-to-back.
- Trap games contribute minimally when predicting outcome of a game where a strong team faces a weak opponent, after controlling for other factors such as home-ice advantage, relative team strengths, and fatigue.
- Persistent narrative around trap games is a cognitive bias caused by memorable anecdotal upsets rather than systematic evidence.

Strong Teams Perform Better in Trap Games



Trap Games Not Important when Predicting Game Outcomes



Source: Natural Stat Trick (2025). Covers all NHL seasons from 2007-08 to 2024-2025. See the full text and code for more details: <https://github.com/hLuo27/projects/tree/develop>